Fireslug Studios

Epi-Derick

Game Design Document

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1. Introduction

1.1. Scope

This document is intended to be read by programmers, artists and producers involved in the design, implementation and testing of Epi-Derick.

1.2. Elevator pitch

Epi-Derick is a puzzle management game set in the UK in an alternate future based on Papers Please - but instead of allowing or denying people entry, you prescribe medications depending on what customers need and how they feel.

1.3. Type Conventions & Colour Key

This document will be written using the Nunito font, as shown like this.
Ideas and concepts will be coloured differently, depending on the source, or action that needs to be taken.

Black	- Settled idea/concept
Blue	- Suggested idea/concept
Green	- Stretch idea/concept
Orange	- Needs review
Red	- Needs change

2. Game Overview

2.1. Game concept

Epi-Derick's objective is to solve customer needs by giving them medications and prescriptions to solve their differing health problems. The player is supposed to feel a mix of time pressure and confusion from different puzzles. Satisfaction will result from working out how to treat progressively more complex health issues.

2.2. Audience

The target audience for this game are those who enjoy management-style puzzle games with little oversight, as well as underlying narratives. Players will be expected to work out what they're doing on their own. Similar games in this area have aspects of this, but often have very one note solutions to the puzzles given. (Usually let an NPC in and out of an area, creating a binary solution to every problem, even if the path to said solution can get progressively more complex.) Epi-Derick seeks to expand on this by offering the complex puzzle mechanic, tied with multiple solutions to each problem.
Age range - 13+

Similar game interests - Papers Please, Not Tonight, Lil' Guardsman, Wilmot's Warehouse

2.3. Genre

Puzzle, Management, Simulation, 3D

2.4. Setting

The game takes place in a dingy pharmacy in a run down part of town. It is based in the real world, in a stylised alternative version of the UK, but with similar issues. The main idea being that this UK also has an NHS, but even more underfunded, so you've been placed in charge of this pharmacy despite being a trainee who has just left university. In this town, a disease is running rampant which turns everyone infected into a clone of patient zero: Derick.

2.5. World structure

The player is limited to the confines of the pharmacy, being unable to move from behind the counter. The most they can see of the pharmacy is what they are able to view from behind the counter. If expanded upon, the player will be able to sit at home and look around their flat from their couch.

2.6. Player

The player plays as an overworked trainee pharmacist, fresh out of university. The game is single-player.

2.7. Core loop

The basic game loop goes as follows:

1. Player starts the day, entering the pharmacy, receiving any deliveries, having the freedom to organise the store to their liking, and read any documents, instructions, pamphlets or manuals. They can then open the store when they're ready.
2. Once the player has opened up for the day, customers will begin entering the store. The player can then talk to each customer to solve whatever need they have. Some may have ailments they want help with, some will have

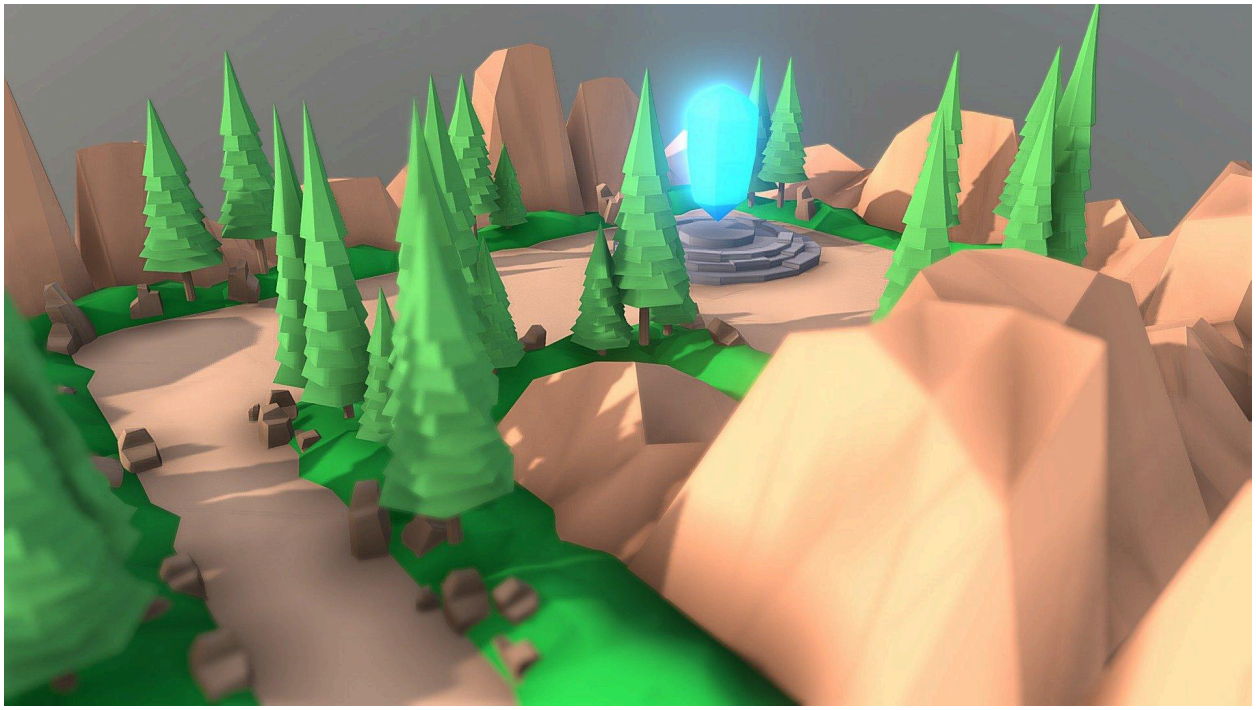
prescriptions that need filling, others might have general enquiries or just be there to waste your time. How fast a player can process customers depends on the dialogue options they choose. The player must try to pick the most helpful dialogue options depending on the personality of the customer, which they can ascertain from the customer's opening line. Once this stage starts, the player is timed, and is aiming to process as many customers as they can in the allotted time of the day.

3. Once the day is over (once the time is up), the player will be free to serve the last customer at their pace, and will close the store once they are dealt with. After closing the store the player is given a rundown of how they did in the form of a daily report, letting them know how many customers they managed to serve, as well as how many profits they received, and how many customers left satisfied, or otherwise.
4. After the report has been read by the player, they can choose to order new medication stock from their computer before leaving.
5. Lastly the player will go home, this will take the form of just a 2D screen giving information. If possible, instead you will return to your flat, having the freedom to watch TV or read a newspaper for some narrative background.
6. After every few days, the player could get the option to purchase new upgrades for the store like decorations which reduce customer agitation, Automation for certain systems like medication preparation, and access to more expensive medication increasing profit margins.

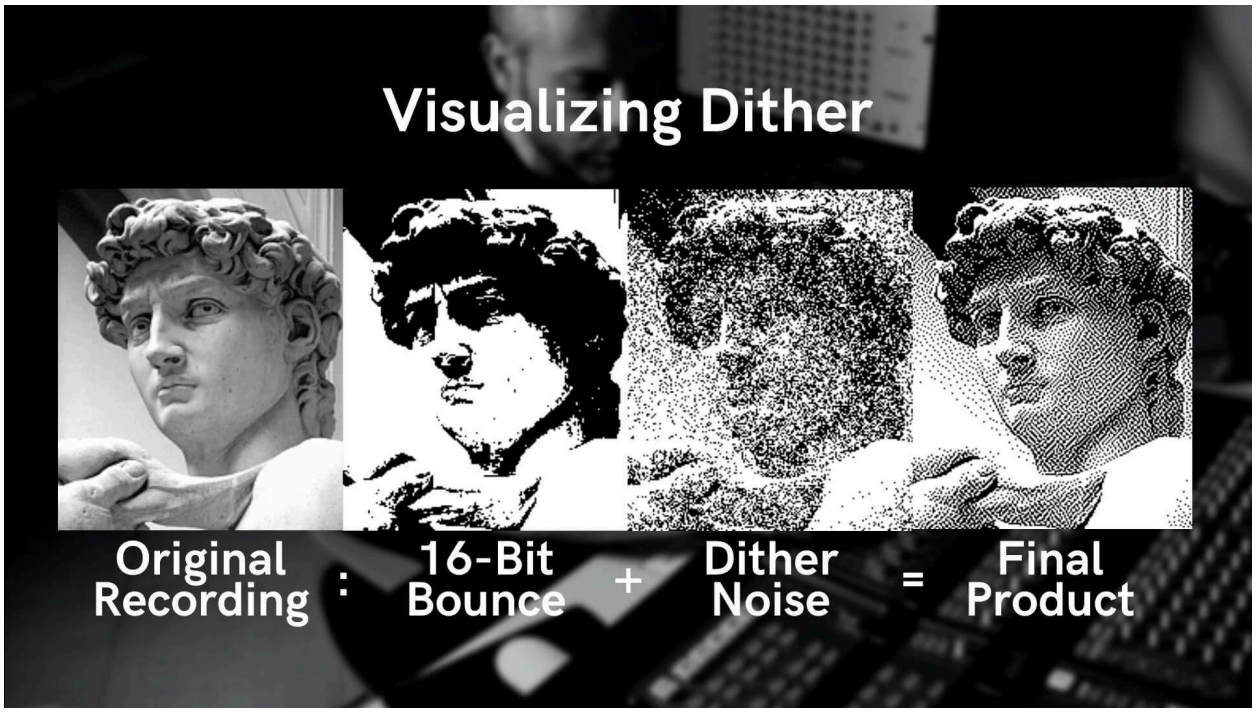
2.8. Look & Feel

The game will have a low-poly pixelated look. This will be from a mix of low-poly models, and the use of dithering and posterization. The goal is to have something akin to the visual style of Buckshot Roulette.

Low-poly:



Dithering:



Posterization:

Final:

3. Gameplay

3.1. Objectives

The main objective is to survive each day while satisfying as many customers as possible with the time given. While the primary focus is processing customers, the secondary goal is to keep customers happy to maintain a good reputation for the player and the pharmacy as a whole, which will have different benefits for the player as well as consequences for the story and ending.

Introduction

3.2. Progression

As the game progresses, the player will be presented with increasingly complex medical issues which involve more stringent remedy requirements (e.g. a heart medication might have the restriction that it cannot be given to anyone using blood pressure medication, requiring the use of a different heart medication. The player will be expected to notice this, and failure to do so will have increasingly more serious consequences.) Furthermore, as the days go on, more and more medications will be introduced to the player, with a variety of upgrades that they can purchase to make the gameplay easier in different aspects. Customers may also get increasingly more hostile, requiring different dialogue responses to deal with them. Part way through the game you will be instructed to enforce euthanasia on the clones by way of triggering side effects from medication to limit the spread of the Epi-Derick.

3.2.1. Difficulty

Difficulty is mostly static, growing in time as the days go on. If possible, there will be an added difficulty system to affect how quickly the difficulty grows, as well as how complex the customer needs can be. Another idea is the addition of hostile customers, which require even more attention to mitigate. Even further is to add a new game+ mode with fake joke illnesses which will have even more complex solutions. When the player gets a customer's medication wrong, by way of choosing the wrong prescription or assessing the patient's ailment incorrectly, the player character will receive a phone call from management, warning them that they have assessed a patient's needs incorrectly.

See the table below for difficulty information.

Difficulty Settings

3.3. Play flow

Other than the core loop, there are other factors that play into how the game progresses. There is a reputation score system which is affected by how well you treat the customers throughout the game. This score affects the final ending of the game. Money is important to manage also, as if the player doesn't serve enough customers, they won't get enough money, and they are responsible for paying for their rent. If they don't, it's game over.

4. Mechanics

4.1 Systems & Scripts

Below is a list of mechanics/systems that will be required.

- Menu controller - Basic menu navigation, menu tracking
- Dialogue system - Dialogue trees, Customer interactions
- Game screen management - Game screen navigation, screen tracking
- In-game time tracking - Timer for game days
- Save system - Save system for saving progress when able
- Stock system - For counting how much stock player has in-store
- Ordering system - For generating medication per player orders
- Audio system - For playing sounds and music
- Localisation system - For translating text into different languages
- New game system - For setting up new game, starting generation,
- Treatment calculation system - For calculating medication effects
- Customer loading system - Generates the customer line for the day
- Hint system - System for generating hints
- Upgrade system - System for upgrading the store
- Random generation systems
    - Customers - Randomly generate customers
    - Medication - Randomly generate medication
- Object interaction system
    - Movement - Picking up, putting down, drop, rotate
    - Inspection - Zoom in
    - Assembly - Dragging, collision
- Scoring system
    - Scoring - Scores how well a player did in a day
    - Money - Tracks how much money a player has
    - Reputation - Tracks how much reputation a player has

- Base scripts
    - Customer - Holds data for current customer
    - Medications - Holds data for current medication
    - Upgrades - Holds data for upgrades
    - Condition names - Holds data for every possible condition name

Below is a list of scriptable object data sheets that will be required:

- Customer data - Contains all data about a customer
- Customer attitudes - Attitude type data, with associated dialogue
- Medication data - Contains all data about a medication
- Health condition data - Contains all data about a health condition
- Side-effects data - Contains all data about a side-effect
- Upgrades data - Contains all data about an upgrade

Below are databases for certain information:

List of Addresses

List of Drugs

Illness Data

4.2. Rules & Actions

Player actions are dictated by what interaction screen they are present at:

- Customer Interaction Screen
    - Talk to customer
    - Take objects from customer
    - Give objects to the customer
    - Open store
- Workstation Screen
    - Pick up and inspect objects
    - Interact with and inspect objects
    - Put down/drop objects
    - Assemble prescriptions (either in a box or bottle)
- Stock Room Screen
    - Pull out shelves
    - Push back shelves
    - Place medication in shelf
    - Take medication from shelf
- Pharmacy View Screen

    - Take delivery
    - Yell at hostile customers
- Flat (Home) Screen
    - Watch TV
    - Read newspaper
    - Sleep
    - Order Supplies

4.3. Game universe

The entire world is essentially just the pharmacy and the players flat. Customers load outside the store outside of the player's view, and walk in constantly whenever the store is open depending on a few factors.

4.4. Physics

The physics are minimal, and have little impact on the game. Dropping an item at the workstation causes it to fall down and possibly roll around, but that's the most in terms of physics that will be present. If possible, if bottles are implemented as an upgrade, the player will be able to rotate and shake the bottle to see pills inside the bottle move and bounce around.

4.5. Economy

There is no economy present in the game other than the money the player earns from serving customers. The player is able to spend money by ordering new medications and stock, paying rent, and purchasing upgrades.

4.6. Character movement

Character movement is minimal, the player can move between set positions behind the counter in order to access the medications and service desk. NPCs do move, but simply to enter and navigate the store. If time allows, the player will be able to freely look around the store.

4.6.1. Player interaction

The player can interact with customers, and various objects and medications at their workstation. They are also able to interact with a computer to see various bits of information and possibly also upgrade the store.

4.7. Game menus / Screens

The game will have multiple different menus, but they will all be diegetic in nature.

- Title screen / Main menu
    - Setting / Design:
        - The main menu will look like a wide view of the inside of the store, and transition to a view of the monitor when adjusting settings.
    - Options:
        - Start
        - Options / Settings
        - Credits
        - Quit

- Start menu
    - Setting / Design:
        - The start menu, when selected, will transition to the monitor view and show the options on the screen.
    - Options:
        - New store (New game)
            - Endless Mode (Day 30 difficulty, continuous until player fails)
            - Hardcore Mode (Can't restart days, or return to previous days)
        - Return to work (Load file)
            - Store selection (File selection)
                - Store 1
                - Store 2
                - Store 3
        - Sell / Shut down store (Delete file)
            - Store selection (File selection)
                - Store 1
                - Store 2
                - Store 3
        - Return to Main Menu

- Options / Settings menu
    - Setting / Design:
        - This again, when selected, will transition to the monitor view and show the various settings that can be adjusted.

    - Options:
        - See **4.6.3. Game options**
        - Return to Main Menu

- Loading screen
    - Setting / Design:
        - Setting / Design:
            - Just a black screen, with an animated logo in the bottom left or right.
            - Could show newspaper clippings with different headlines and photos of recent events which have been affected by the Epi-Derick.

- Credits screen
    - Setting / Design:
        - Will slowly scroll through the names of people involved. If viewed after game completion, it will show with newspaper clippings of events that take place after the games ending depending on the players choices.

- Pause menu
    - Setting / Design:
        - This menu can be brought up anytime, and should just be an overlay screen. If possible, it would be preferable to instead zoom into the player's watch which acts as the pause screen.
    - Options:
        - Return to work
        - Restart day (Disabled on hardcore mode)
        - BGM Volume
        - SFX Volume
        - Ambience Volume
        - Quit

- Terminal menu
    - Setting / Design:
        - This menu is found on the computer terminal, and allows the player to select different computer-specific menus. It takes the form of a dated computer menu.

    - Options:
        - GCD Browser (Must be unlocked as an upgrade, GCD stands for Global Codification of Disorders)
        - Daily Reports
        - Ordering
        - Store Improvements

- GCD Browser menu (Disabled on endless mode)
    - Setting / Design:
        - This menu is found on the computer terminal, and allows the player to quickly search for different information on illnesses or medications, acting as a quick reference guide. It takes the form of a search engine.
    - Options:
        - Search
            - Select result
            - Back to search view
        - Illness View
            - Select illness
            - Back to illness view
        - Medicine View
            - Select medicine
            - Back to medicine view
        - Back to terminal menu

- Daily reports menu (Disabled on endless mode)
    - Setting / Design:
        - This menu is found on the computer terminal, and allows the player to see the daily report for each day they've played, as well as return to previous days. It takes the form of a digital calendar month.
    - Options:
        - Select day
            - View report
            - Load this day (Player will lose all progress made after this day, disabled on hardcore mode)
            - Back to month view
        - Back to terminal menu

- Ordering menu

        - Setting / Design:
            - This menu is found on the computer terminal, and allows the player to order stock that they're low on. It takes the form of a digital shopping screen.
        - Options:
            - Current orders
                - See order details
                - Cancel order
                - Back to ordering menu
            - Order stock
                - Select item
                - See item details
                - Select quantity
                - Order
                - Back to ordering menu
            - Back to terminal menu

- Store improvements / Upgrades menu
    - Setting / Design:
        - This menu is found on the computer terminal, and allows the player to upgrade different aspects of their store. It takes the form of a different shopping screen.
    - Options:
        - Store
        - Workstation
        - Security
        - Back to terminal menu

4.7.1. Saving

The game automatically saves at the end of each day. In normal mode, the player will be able to load previous days, and restart days halfway through. These options won't be possible in hardcore mode.

4.7.2. Game options

- Graphical

- Window mode
  - Fullscreen
  - Borderless
  - Windowed
- Aspect ratio
  - 16:10
  - 16:9
  - 4:3
- Resolution
  - 16:10 [These show when aspect ratio is set to 16:10]
    - 3840 x 2400 - WQUXGA
    - 2560 x 1600 - WQXGA
    - 1920 x 1200 - WUXGA
    - 1680 x 1050 - WSXGA+
    - 1440 x 900 - WXGA+
    - 1280 x 800 - WXGA
    - 1024 x 640
  - 16:9 [These show when aspect ratio is set to 16:9]
    - 3840 x 2160 - 4K UHD
    - 3200 x 1800 - QHD+
    - 2560 x 1440 - HWQHD
    - 1920 x 1080 - FHD / Full HD (1080p)
    - 1600 x 900 - HD+
    - 1366 x 768 - WXGA
    - 1280 x 720 - SD / HD ready (720p)
  - 4:3 [These show when aspect ratio is set to 4:3]
    - 4096 x 3072 - HXGA 4K (HDTV)
    - 3840 x 2880 - 4K UHD
    - 2048 x 1536 - QXGA
    - 1920 x 1440 - 2.76M3 (1080P)
    - 1600 x 1200 - UXGA
    - 1280 x 960 - SXGA– (720P)
    - 1024 x 768 - XGA

- Audio
  - BGM Volume
  - Ambience Volume
  - SFX Volume

- Gameplay
  - Date Format
    - DD-MM-YYYY
    - MM-DD-YYYY
    - YYYY-MM-DD
  - Language

    Format: [Name in setting, Name in local, Flag]
    - Afrikaans
    - Arabic
    - Bengali
    - Chinese, Simplified
    - Chinese, Traditional
    - Czech
    - Danish
    - Dutch
    - English
    - Farsi
    - Filipino
    - Finnish
    - French
    - French, Canadian
    - German
    - Greek
    - Hindi
    - Italian
    - Japanese
    - Korean
    - Lithuanian
    - Norwegian
    - Polish
    - Portuguese
    - Portuguese, Brazilian
    - Russian
    - Spanish

        - Spanish, Latin
        - Swedish
        - Turkish
        - Ukrainian
        - Australian
        - Cat
        - Dog
        - Klingon
        - Pirate
        - Dothraki
        - Pig latin
    - Colour Blind Mode
        - On
        - Off

4.8. Assets

[Required Asset List]

4.9. Dialogue

Dialogue will be controlled using a dialogue tree, with the player able to ask the customer a variety of questions to try and help solve their issues. See the dialogue trees for more information.
[Character Dialogue Trees]

4.9.1. Tutorials

Tutorials will be given diegetically via emails within the game

5. Graphics & Audio

5.1. Visual system

The game is 3D with limited movement taking place in a small space. This is to reduce the workload and keep the game within scope. The visual style is grungy and bleak. The game will make use of dithering and posterization to produce this style. The inspiration for this comes from Buckshot Roulette.

5.1.1. Player camera

The player camera is locked onto certain screens and all gameplay takes place on . If possible, when the player is on the customer interaction screen, there will be a free look option to look around the pharmacy.

5.2. Interface

Most UI will be diegetically implemented via the monitor on the players counter. Other interactions like dialogue options are accessed via the player's notebook.

5.3. Audio system

The audio system is very simple, background music will play during the title screen and gameplay. Sound effects will play using basic triggers. The most complex audio system is speech sound effect synthesis which is covered below.

5.3.1. Game music

The type of game music is electronic, with inspirations from multiple different genres. Namely vaporwave - specifically VHS pop and some lo-fi.

5.3.2. Audio look & feel

The game audio is supposed to be oppressive and bleak. It's a little dystopian in nature, and run down. Inspiration comes from old era mall and weather channel music - the game isn't supposed to take place in the past, but the idea is that the store is too cheap to buy anything newer, though with many effects will be added to add to the ambience.

5.3.3. Speech audio

!

6. Story and narrative

6.1. Backstory

A disease has turned the citizens of this town into clones of its patient zero, Derrick. This has caused issues beyond counting and has caused a massive uptick in medical issues due to the lack of biodiversity.

6.2. Main plot

After a recent outbreak of a disease that turns the infected into clones of a man called Derick, you must run a pharmacy to treat the infected with their various health concerns.

6.2.1. Plot progression

Part way through the game you will be instructed to enforce euthanasia on the clones by way of triggering side effects from medication to limit the spread of the Epi-Derick.

6.3. Cutscenes

Simple cutscenes will be added to the beginning of the game as an introduction, and at the end of the game to reflect the choices the players made, depending on the ending the player is awarded.

6.4. Endings

The game will have 6 possible endings, depending on the choices the player makes throughout the game.

The first three are “Game Over” endings where the game ends prematurely due to the player making a “bad” decision. These include:

1. “Negligence” - The player caused the death of an innocent patient, by way of prescribing something which killed them, before day 20.
2. “Destitution” - The player ran out of money, meaning they couldn’t pay their bills, or the cost of running the pharmacy.
3. “Disobedience” - The player refused to follow orders from their superiors, which commanded them to kill as many dericks as possible.

The remaining three endings are awarded after game completion, and change depending on the reputation the player gains. These include:

4. “Salvation” - The good reputation ending, gained after treating patients exceedingly well and efficiently.
5. “Purgatory” - The neutral reputation ending, gained after treating the patients well enough, an exceedingly average effort.

6. “Damnation” - The bad reputation ending, gained after treating patients terribly, doing all but killing them in the process.

The nature of these endings is further explained here:
Endings

7. Characters

7.1. Main character

The main character is the player character, who is a trainee pharmacist fresh out of university. They have little experience and the day to day operations of the store are thrust upon them by their manager, leaving them little choice in the matter.

7.2. Supporting characters

The only other main characters the player interacts with that aren’t generated are:
These are:

- Sebastian Ward - This is the delivery guy who is assigned to the player’s store area. Anytime the player orders any stock from the computer terminal, they come round first thing the following morning with the delivery. They’re amicable, and quite upbeat. They’re probably the closest thing the player character has to a friend. His nickname is Seb.

7.3. Generated characters

- Customers - These are the main clientele of the pharmacy, which come with all sorts of attitudes. While many can be difficult, most are just looking for help with whatever problem ails them. Or maybe just to ask the occasional question.
- Hostile Customers - These customers are troublemakers, and almost always cause problems when they show up. There’s a variety of different ones all who cause issues in different ways. The only thing for sure though is the player doesn’t want them in their store.

8. Game world

8.1. Look & Feel of the world

While taking place in an alternate reality, the pharmacy looks rundown and grungy to reflect the poor economic state of both the town and player character.

8.2. Locations

Main Locations include the Pharmacy and the main character's apartment.

8.3. Levels

Every day of the game takes place in the pharmacy, with increasingly difficult customers and orders as the days go by.

9. Miscellaneous

9.1. Achievements

There are 32 achievements in the game, they are listed below.
Steam Achievements